

What Beats What: Reading Coverage and Pass Concepts Versus Coverages

How a quarterback works out the coverage in the second after the snap, which pass concepts are built to beat which coverages, and why every ‘beater’ is a bet, not a guarantee.

Third-and-7, early in the second quarter. Before the snap the broadcast’s high camera shows two safeties, one on each side of the field, about 13 yards deep. The quarterback takes the snap, drops, and stares straight down the middle of the field at the right-hand safety, shoulders square, as if he is about to throw a deep in-cut right at him. The safety takes two steps toward the middle. Then the quarterback turns his head, resets his feet and throws to the left: a 16-yard completion to a receiver standing all alone in the space the safety had been guarding. On the replay the analyst circles the safety and says, admiringly, “he *looked him off*.” A few plays later the same analyst says something else you have heard a hundred times: “That’s a great call against that coverage.” What does it mean for a play to be “great against” a coverage? How does the quarterback know, in the second and a half he has, which coverage it is? And if offenses know which plays beat which coverages, why doesn’t every pass work? This chapter puts the two halves of the book you have read so far, the pass concepts of Part 4 and the coverages of Part 6, on the same field.

You’ll be able to...

- Walk through the quarterback’s coverage read in order: the shell before the snap, the rotation at it, the key defender after it, and the throw that defender gives him, including how he moves a defender with his eyes (a look-off).
- Read the concept-by-coverage matrix and explain the reasoning behind any cell: why smash beats Cover 2, why flood and four verticals hurt Cover 3, why dagger and scissors attack quarters, why mesh punishes man.
- Explain why “beaters” are bets, not guarantees: disguise, match rules, execution and the defense’s own call sheet all move the odds, and charting data shows how small the real edges are.
- Recognise a two-way concept (one with a man answer and a zone answer) and say why coordinators love them on third down.
- Name the defense’s counters (Cover 3 match against four verticals, Palms against smash) and the offense’s counter-counters.
- Identify the coverage one second after the snap and predict the open receiver before the ball is thrown.

i You'll need

This chapter joins Parts 4 and 6, so it leans on both. One line each:

- **Disguise and rotation** (Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage): the shell before the snap is a hypothesis, not an answer. Defenses disguise and rotate at the snap: two-high into one-high (Cover 3, or a robber in the hole) or one-high into Cover 2. After the snap, the middle of the field is either closed (MOFC, one safety in the deep middle) or open (MOFO, two safeties splitting it).
- **The concepts** (Dropback Concepts): a pass concept is a set of routes built to put one conflict defender in a bind, with a high-low or a horizontal stretch. The ones this chapter uses: smash (hitch outside, corner route over it), flood (three levels on one sideline), levels and drive (two in-breakers at two depths), dagger (a seam that clears, a deep dig behind it), Y-cross, mesh (two shallow crossers that brush past each other), four verticals, post-wheel, scissors and yankee. A man-beater wins against man coverage, usually with crossing routes or a rub.
- **Man coverage** (Man Coverage): Cover 1 is man with one deep safety; Cover 0 is man with none. A man defender's leverage follows his help: with a deep safety inside, he takes away the outside.
- **The zones** (Part 6): Cover 3 is three deep, four under, with a curl-flat defender on each side; Cover 3 match carries vertical routes with a seam-flat defender. Cover 2 is two deep halves and five under, with hard corners who squat in the flats; Tampa 2 sends the Mike linebacker down the middle; 2-Man is two deep with man underneath. Quarters gives four defenders a deep quarter each, with read safeties keyed on the inside receiver (#2) and corners playing MOD; Cover 6 is quarters on one half and Cover 2 on the other; Palms is a quarters check in which the corner and safety trade jobs on #1 and #2.
- **Pressure** (Zone Blitzes, Fire Zones, and Simulated Pressure): a fire zone rushes five with three under and three deep; when rushers outnumber blockers the ball goes to the hot route.
- **The quarterback** (Quarterback Play): a progression is the order of his looks, run on the clock of his feet, ending in the checkdown; every look is answered by one key defender; an anticipation throw leaves before the receiver is open.

Reading the diagrams: offense is blue circles (X and Z the outside receivers, H the slot, Y a tight end flexed out like a second slot, Q the quarterback, R the back, C the center). Defense is outlined orange squares: E and T the linemen, M the Mike and W the Will linebacker, \$ the nickel (slot cornerback), CB the cornerbacks, FS and SS the free and strong safety. Solid blue arrows are routes, dashed orange arrows zone drops, dotted orange lines man assignments, and the dashed brown arrow is the pass. A **green ring** marks the defender to watch; a dotted green arrow is the quarterback's eyes, and the green patch is the window the ball goes to. Small numbers on the left edge are yards past the line of scrimmage (the darker blue line); the orange line is the line to gain. Left and right are the offense's.

The question under every pass

Every pass play starts with a question the quarterback has to answer faster than any other decision in sport: **what coverage is this?** Not because coaches love labels, but because the coverage decides where the empty grass will be. Cover 2 leaves the sideline between its squatting corner and its deep safety; Cover 3 leaves the flats and the seams; quarters leaves the space behind its read safeties' eyes; man leaves whoever loses his one-on-one. Know the coverage and you know, roughly, where the ball should go before the receivers have finished their first steps.

Quarterback Play showed the quarterback's clock: a drop timed to the depth of the routes, a progression run one look at a time, a key defender answering each look. It left one thing out on purpose, because Part 6 had not yet taught the coverages: *how he decides which defender is the key, and which side to look at first*. That is the coverage read. Coaches teach it in many dialects, but nearly all of them reduce to four steps, in order.

1. **Shell, before the snap.** One deep safety or two? Corners pressed or off? Is anyone creeping? This produces a *hypothesis*: "two-high, corners squatting, probably Cover 2."
2. **Rotation, at the snap.** Did the safeties stay where they were, or did one spin to the middle and the other come down? One second after the snap, is the middle of the field open or closed? This confirms or overturns the hypothesis.
3. **Key defender, after the snap.** Given the coverage, which single defender decides whether the called concept works? For smash it is the cornerback; for flood the curl-flat defender; for dagger the safety and then the linebacker; for four verticals the deep middle safety.
4. **Throw.** Read that defender and throw where he isn't. If the answer is "nowhere," move to the next read, and eventually to the checkdown.

Here are all four in one play, from the quarterback's side.

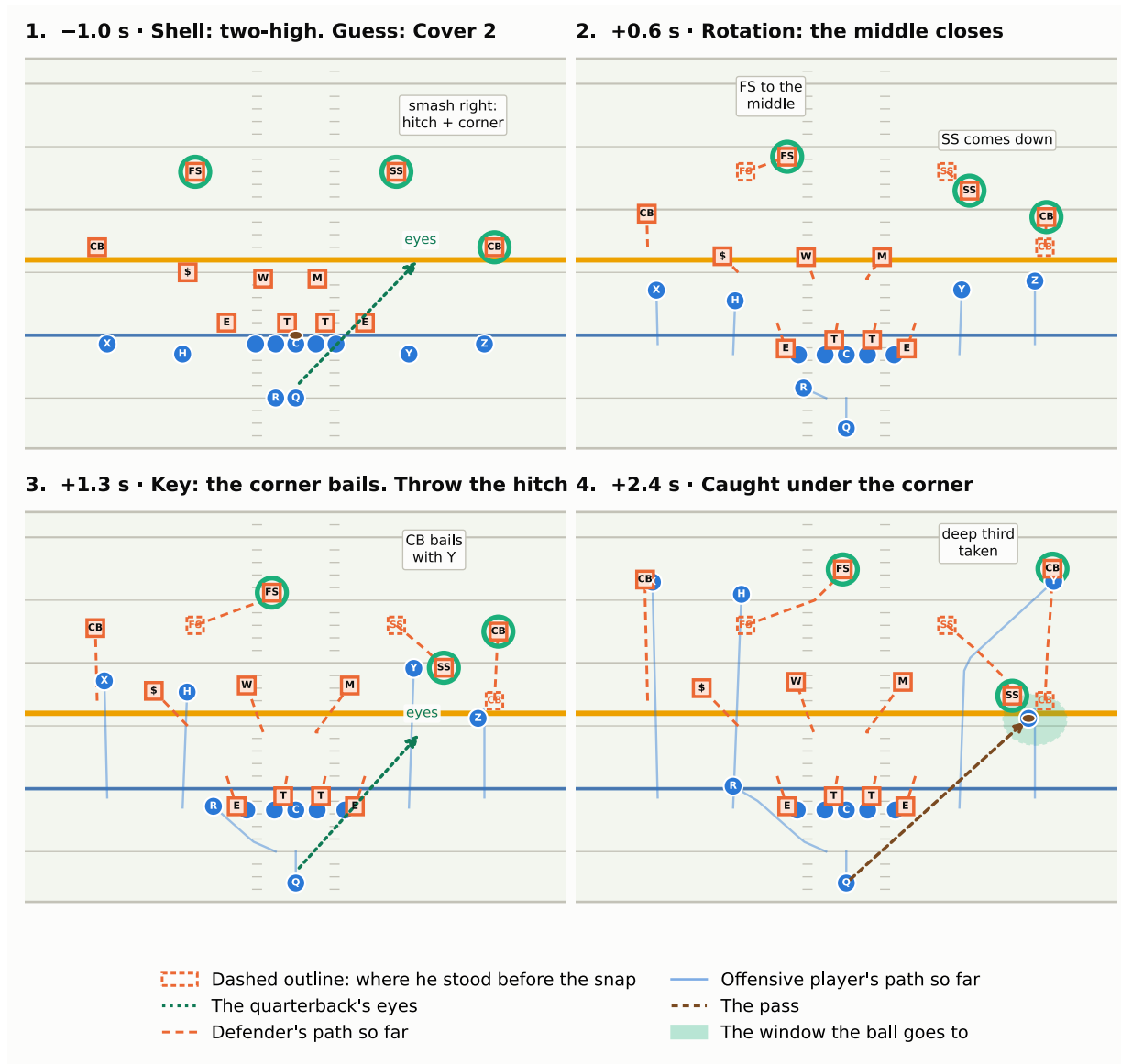


Figure 1: How the quarterback reads coverage, in four moments of one simulated play (a frame strip; a video on the web). The call is smash to the right: Z runs a 6-yard hitch, Y a corner route over him. Panel 1, before the snap: two safeties 13 yards deep (ringed) and corners 7 off. The hypothesis is Cover 2, so the quarterback's eyes start on the right corner (ringed), expecting him to squat on the hitch and give up the corner route. Panel 2, 0.6 seconds after the snap: the free safety (FS) has turned for the deep middle and the strong safety (SS) is coming down toward the flat on the smash side. The middle has closed: this is Cover 3 (a sky rotation), and the hypothesis is dead. Panel 3, the key: the right corner, now a deep-third defender, bails with Y's corner route, so the high read is covered and the low one is open. The ball comes out at 1.3 seconds as Z turns. Panel 4: Z catches it under the bailing corner, with the rotating safety arriving a step late. The dashed outlines show where the safeties and the right corner stood before the snap.

Notice what the quarterback did *not* do. He did not decide where to throw before the snap and then throw there; that is how the rotation in Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage produced its interception. He also did not wait to see a receiver come open, which would have been too late: Z's hitch is only open for the half-second before the strong safety arrives. He let one defender, the corner, make the decision for him, and the concept was built so that whatever that defender did, one of the two routes would be on the wrong side of him.

That is also why smash survived the rotation. Smash is built first of all to beat Cover 2, but its read (corner sits, throw over him; corner bails, throw under him) still works against a Cover 3 corner, who bails. The quarterback didn't need to change the play. He needed only to know which half of it the coverage had handed him.

Step 1: the shell, and what it is worth

The pre-snap read is worth more than its reputation suggests, even in an era of disguise. First, it narrows the menu. A defense showing two deep safeties and two off corners is very unlikely to be in Cover 0 one second later; a defense showing one safety in the middle and pressed corners is unlikely to end up in quarters. Each shell makes some coverages *easy* to reach and others a long run away, and as Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage showed, every defender has to stand where his real job is still reachable. Second, the shell sets up everything that has to be decided before the ball moves: the protection, which side the progression starts on, whether to change the play (check-with-me offenses give the quarterback a menu at the line), and whether to take a shot (the *alert*, later in this chapter).

What the shell can't do is name the coverage. The quarterback treats it as a short list ranked by likelihood: "two-high: Cover 2, quarters or 2-Man, unless they rotate." The rest of the read decides between them.

Step 2: rotation, and the one-second answer

The single most useful question after the snap is the one you can ask from your couch: **one second after the snap, how many safeties are deep in the middle of the field?** One, and the middle is closed: Cover 1 or Cover 3 (or a fire zone, which is Cover 3 behind a blitz). Two, splitting the field, and it is open: Cover 2, Tampa 2, 2-Man, quarters or Cover 6. None: Cover 0, and the ball should already be on its way. Then the corners separate the members of each family: in the closed family, corners who turn and run with their receivers mean Cover 1 and corners who bail with their eyes on the quarterback mean Cover 3; in the open family, corners who squat in the flats mean Cover 2 (or the Cover 2 side of Cover 6), corners who backpedal and read mean quarters, and corners who trail their man mean 2-Man.

The quarterback answers that question with his first glance after the snap, often while he is still dropping. He does not need to see every defender. He needs the two safeties, because they are the ones a disguise moves, and the corner on the side he is reading.

Step 3: the key defender for each coverage

Once the coverage has a name, the key defender follows from the concept and the coverage together. The table pairs each coverage with the defender quarterbacks are usually taught to read against it and where the ball tends to go. It is a summary of Part 6 from the offense's side.

Table 1: The quarterback's key against each coverage family. Typical, not universal: staffs teach different keys for the same coverage, and the concept called changes which defender matters.

Coverage (one second after the snap)	Middle of the field	The defender to read	Where the ball usually goes
Cover 0	no deep safety	the free rusher, if any (the hot read)	the hot throw; a quick man-beater; any one-on-one deep if the protection holds
Cover 1	closed	the matchup, and the robber if there is one	the receiver who beats his man; crossers and rubs; away from the robber
Cover 3	closed	the curl-flat defender; the post safety for seams	the flat or the curl behind him; the seams; the hitch under a bailing corner; flood
Cover 3 match	closed	the seam-flat defender (did he carry #2?)	the flat he left; post-wheel; the checkdown
Cover 2	open	the corner (sideline); the safeties (middle)	the corner route over the squat corner; the hole shot; the deep middle between the safeties
Tampa 2	open, Mike running the middle	the Mike (which seam did he carry?)	the other seam; the hole shot; the curl windows
2-Man	open	the trailing underneath defenders	out-breaking routes away from their inside leverage; the back; a quarterback scramble
Quarters	open	the read safety (what did #2 do?)	behind the safety once #2 takes him deep (dagger, scissors); quick outs to #2
Fire zone	closed	the dropper and the seam-flat defenders	the seams; the window behind the dropper; never the hot throw he is standing in

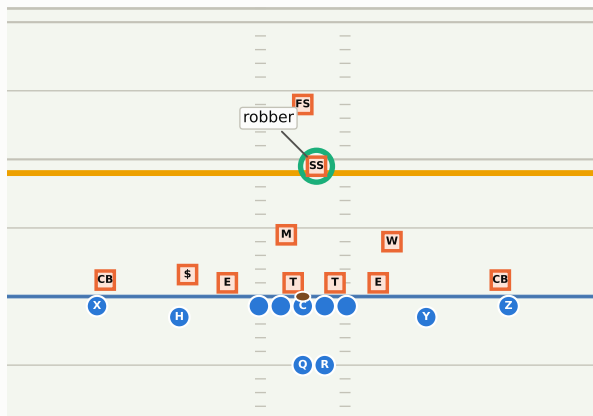
The key is almost always one of three kinds of defender: the **conflict defender** the concept was built against (the corner in smash, the curl-flat defender in flood), the **safety who reads the quarterback** (the post safety against four verticals, the robber against in-cuts), or, against man, **the matchup itself**, the receiver's defender, read by his leverage and the help behind him.

Moving a defender with your eyes: the look-off

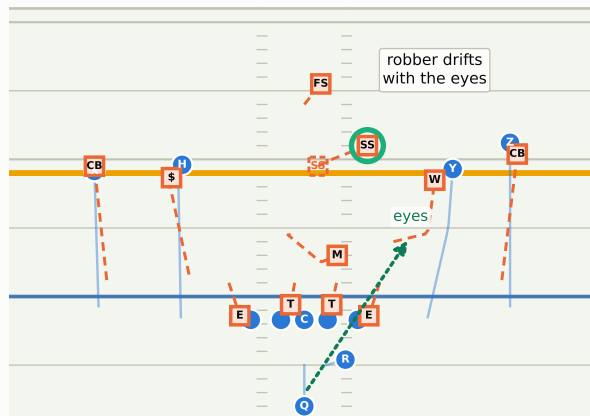
Every defender in the second category has a weakness built into his job. A post safety, a robber, a Tampa 2 Mike and most zone linebackers are taught to watch the quarterback, because the quarterback's eyes and shoulders tell them where the ball is going before it leaves his hand. That makes them movable.

A **look-off** is the quarterback deliberately looking at one receiver or area, often turning his shoulders that way too, to pull a defender who reads his eyes toward it, and then throwing somewhere else, into the space that defender left. It is the quarterback's half of the disguise contest: the defense lies with its alignment before the snap; the quarterback lies with his head after it.

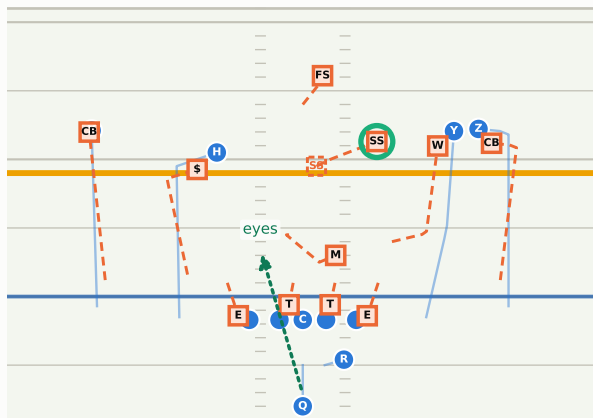
1. Snap · Cover 1, the SS in the hole as robber



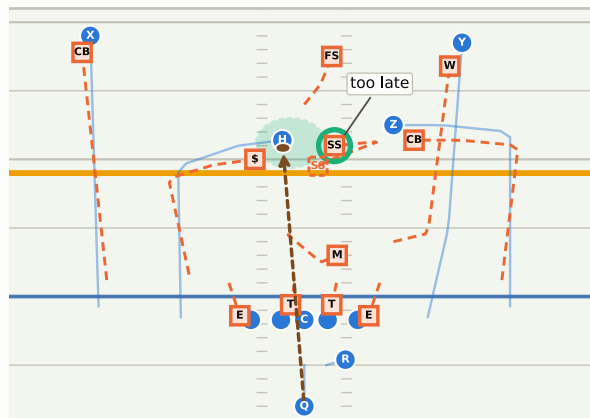
2. +1.5 s · Eyes right on Z's dig: the robber follows



3. +1.95 s · Eyes snap left: throw to H



4. +3.0 s · Caught where the robber was



Dashed outline: where he stood before the snap
 The quarterback's eyes
 Defender's path so far

Offensive player's path so far
 The pass
 The window the ball goes to

Figure 2: A look-off against Cover 1 robber, simulated. Panel 1: man coverage, with the corners pressed, the nickel (\$) on H, the Will on Y and the Mike on the back (who stays in to block), one deep safety, and the strong safety (SS, ringed) sitting in the hole as a robber, free to jump any in-breaking route. Panel 2, 1.5 seconds after the snap: the quarterback's eyes and shoulders are on Z's dig coming in from the right, and the robber, who reads the quarterback, has drifted with them. Panel 3: the eyes snap back to the left and the ball comes out to H, breaking inside on his in-cut, with the nickel trailing him from outside. Panel 4: H catches it at 11 yards in the space the robber left; the robber, coming back, is about three and a half yards short. The dashed outline shows where the robber started.

Why does the robber bite? Because his job is to be right about in-breaking throws, and the best evidence he has is the quarterback. A robber who ignores the quarterback's eyes and simply sits in the middle is easy to throw around; one who reads them gets interceptions. The look-off turns his best evidence into bad evidence. The same logic works on the deep middle safety against four verticals (Cover 3 drew it: the quarterback looks at one seam, the safety leans, the ball goes to the other) and on a Tampa 2 Mike deciding which seam to carry.

What a look-off costs. Time, mostly. Holding a defender with your eyes takes a beat, perhaps three to five tenths of a second, and every beat is one more for the pass rush. So the look-off is usually built into the play's timing rather than added to it: the first read of a progression doubles as the look-off for the second, as in the figure, where the quarterback had a real reason to look at Z's dig before coming back to H. It also takes a quarterback who can reset his feet and throw accurately to the other side of the field without a wasted step. A look-off by a quarterback whose feet don't follow his eyes is just a late throw.

The defense's answer. Coaches teach the eye-readers to "read through" the quarterback: to take their cue from his shoulders and the way his feet are pointing rather than his helmet, because a quarterback can turn his head cheaply but has to set his feet to throw. Defenses also mix in defenders who *don't* read the quarterback, such as a robber who reads a receiver instead, so a look-off

aimed at the wrong defender moves nobody. And they disguise who the eye-reader is. A quarterback who looks off a safety who wasn't reading him has wasted his beat.

i Madden vs. real life

In a video game, defenders mostly react to the ball and to their assignments, and where your quarterback's helmet points is rarely part of the contest. On a real field it is one of the most important things he does. NFL coaches grade a quarterback's eyes on film the way they grade his footwork, and the most-praised quarterbacks are the ones whose eyes move defenders. A quarterback who stares at his first read is said to be "staring down" the receiver, and safeties feast on it.

Watching a look-off from the couch

The look-off is one of the few post-snap skills you can see on a broadcast without the All-22 film. Watch the quarterback's helmet, not the ball. If his head goes to one side and the ball comes out to the other, ask *who moved* while his head was turned. On the replay from behind the offense, find the safety or linebacker who took a step toward where the quarterback looked. That step is what the look-off bought.

What beats what: the matrix

Now the question the chapter's title promises. A **coverage beater** is a pass concept whose routes are arranged to attack the known weak spots of a particular coverage, so that if the defense plays that coverage, at least one receiver should come open. Smash against Cover 2 is the textbook case. The phrase is used loosely on broadcasts, often with a confidence the football doesn't support, so here is a tighter version: a beater *raises the odds* against its coverage. It doesn't guarantee anything, and it is usually worse against other coverages. That trade is the subject of the next section; first, the map.

	man			zone				pressure
	Cover 0	Cover 1	2-Man	Cover 2	Cover 3	Cover 3 match	Quarters	Fire zone
Quick game (stick, slant-flat)	+	▪	—	▪	+	▪	+	▪
Smash	▪	—	---	++	+	▪	▪	▪
Flood (sail)	—	—	—	+	++	▪	+	+
Levels / drive	+	+	▪	+	+	▪	—	▪
Dagger	—	▪	—	+	▪	▪	++	—
Y-cross	—	+	▪	▪	++	+	▪	—
Mesh	++	++	+	▪	▪	▪	▪	—
Four verticals	▪	▪	---	+	++	—	—	+
Post-wheel	▪	+	—	▪	+	++	+	▪
Scissors	—	▪	—	+	▪	▪	++	—
Yankee (play-action shot)	▪	+	—	—	++	+	—	—
Screens	+	▪	▪	—	▪	▪	▪	++

■ ++ offense favoured
■ + edge offense
■ ▪ even / depends
■ — edge defense
■ --- defense favoured

Figure 3: The concept-by-coverage matrix: the book's summary, cell by cell, of which side a concept usually favours against each coverage when both are run as drawn. Blue is an edge for the offense, orange an edge for the defense, grey even or 'depends'. These are typical grades from coaching wisdom and the reasoning of Parts 4 and 6, not measured values (the data chart later in the chapter shows how small measured edges are). Read across a row to see where a concept lives and dies: smash is great against Cover 2 and bad against 2-Man; four verticals destroys spot-drop Cover 3 and runs into a wall against 2-Man and Cover 3 match. Read down a column to see a coverage's menu of problems: quarters suffers against dagger and scissors, man coverage against mesh.

Don't memorise the grid; learn to rebuild it. Every cell follows from two questions you already know how to ask. *Where are this coverage's thin spots?* (Part 6.) *Which defender does this concept put in a bind, and does this coverage give that defender help?* (Part 4.) The rest of this section walks the columns, one coverage family at a time, with a picture for each.

Against Cover 2: attack the sideline and the middle

Cover 2 has two deep defenders and five underneath, and its corners squat. That gives it two permanent thin spots: the sideline strip between the squatting corner and the deep-half safety, 12 to 20 yards deep, and the deep middle between the two safeties. Smash attacks the first, four verticals and dagger the second.

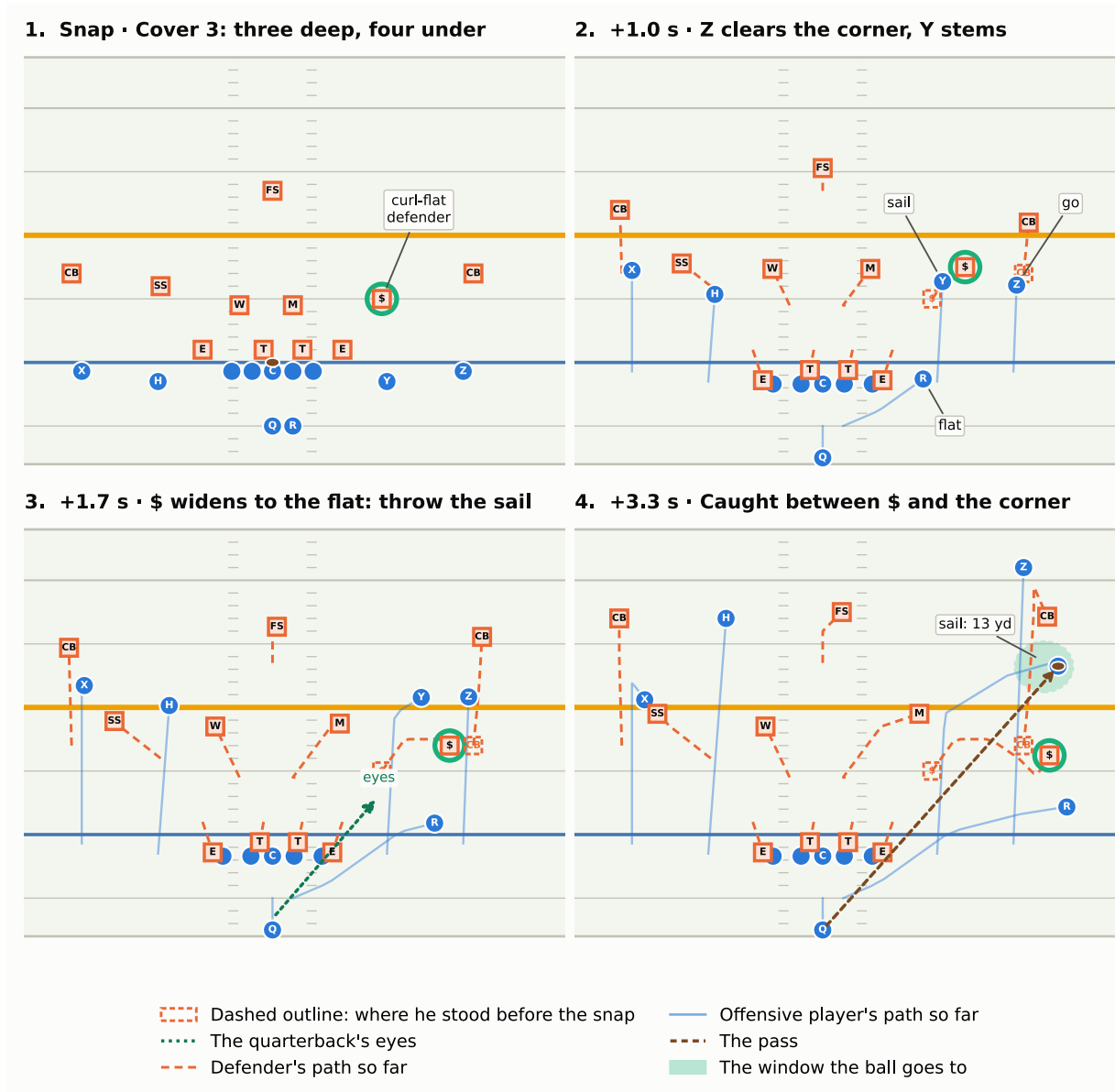


Figure 5: Flood against Cover 3, simulated (a frame strip; a video on the web). Panel 1: one deep safety, corners off, and the nickel (\$, ringed) as the right curl-flat defender, the conflict defender for a flood to the right. Panel 2: Z's go route carries the corner deep, because a Cover 3 corner may never let anyone behind him; Y stems up the field for his sail route; the back releases toward the flat. Panel 3, 1.7 seconds: the nickel, seeing the back come into the flat underneath him, widens for it, and the quarterback throws the sail behind him. Panel 4: Y catches it 13 yards downfield, in the space between the nickel and the corner, who is coming down from 19 yards deep. Three receivers, two defenders: whichever of the two short routes the curl-flat defender takes, the other one is open.

Flood is the purest Cover 3 beater because it uses Cover 3's own rules against it. The corner's rule (never let anyone behind you) means the go route takes him out of the play without a fight. The curl-flat defender's rule (cover the curl, break to the flat) gives one man two receivers. The only help could come from the hook defender inside him or the post safety, and both are watching other routes. Four verticals works on the same arithmetic one level deeper: four vertical routes, three deep defenders, and a post safety who can be moved with the quarterback's eyes. Y-cross and yankee attack the same single deep safety from across the field: a deep crosser behind the linebackers and under a post that holds the safety, a high-low on the one defender in the middle.

What Cover 3 does well hides inside its column, which has no orange because the grid grades whole concepts: almost nothing quick to the inside is free against it, because four underneath defenders and a safety who can drive downhill on in-cuts make slants and short digs a risk unless the receiver wins clean.

Against quarters: make the safety's eyes cost him

Quarters is built to stop most of what beats Cover 2 and Cover 3. It has four defenders who can play deep, so four verticals runs into four men; its safeties read the inside receiver and come down hard on anything short, so the quick game to the inside is dangerous. Its weakness is the reverse of that strength. A read safety's job is decided by one receiver, #2, and a route combination that tells him the wrong thing takes him out of the play.

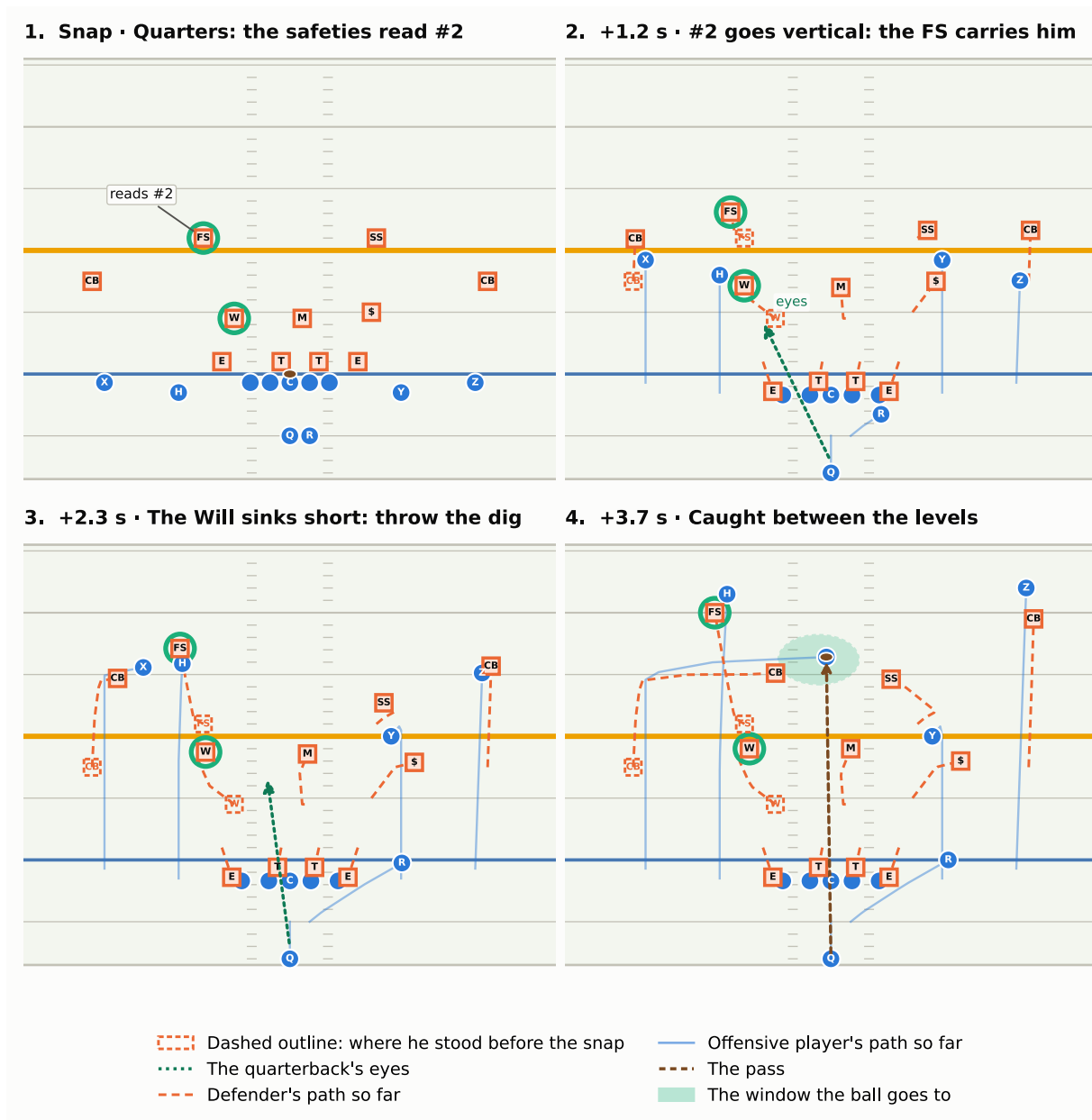


Figure 6: Dagger against quarters, simulated (a frame strip; a video on the web), run to the left this time. Panel 1: quarters from a nickel, the safeties 11 yards deep over the slot receivers, reading #2 (the free safety reads H). Panel 2: H (#2) goes straight up the seam, so by rule the free safety (ringed) carries him deep. The Will (ringed) walls H for a few steps and then sinks to his hook spot; the corner plays X from outside, as quarters corners do. Panel 3, 2.3 seconds: X breaks inside on a deep dig. The safety is gone with the seam, the Will has stopped at 9 yards, and the corner, outside, can only trail. The quarterback, whose eyes went from the safety to the Will, throws as X breaks. Panel 4: the dig is caught at about 16 yards in the middle of the field, under the safeties and over the linebackers. On the right, Y's curl and Z's go keep the strong safety and the Mike busy.

Quarterback Play used this same matchup to show a progression in real time; here, look at it as a lesson about rules. The free safety did exactly what quarters asks: #2 went vertical, so he carried #2. The Will did what he was taught: wall the seam, then sink to his landmark. The corner played the outside receiver from outside, which is what lets quarters take away the deep outside. Every rule was obeyed, and together they left the middle of the field empty at 16 yards for a receiver breaking in from the outside. That is the general shape of attacking quarters: **make #2 tell the safety something, then throw where the safety's answer took**

him from. Scissors does it with crossing deep routes (a post by #1 and a corner by #2 that make the safety and the corner cross and lose their leverage); the quick out by #2 does it underneath, in the first second, before the apex defender can widen (Quarters and the Two-High Match Family); the running back's wheel and the bootleg flood do it at the edge.

What quarters gives the offense for free, if it chooses to take it, is not in the matrix at all: runs. With two safeties at 10 to 12 yards and only six or seven defenders near the line, the box is light, and Run Fits and Box Math showed why a light box invites the offense to hand the ball off. Some of the best answers to two-high coverage aren't passes.

Against man: run away, run through traffic

Man coverage has no zones to stretch, so the stretches of the zone concepts don't apply. Smash against Cover 1 is just two one-on-ones (a hitch against a corner, a corner route against a slot defender) and the free safety in the middle can help on the deep one; flood against man is three one-on-ones near a sideline, which crowds the space the receivers need. Man coverage loses in three different ways: **traffic** (receivers whose paths cross, so a defender chasing one runs into the other: mesh and every rub), **leverage** (routes that break away from the side the defender is protecting: the out against inside leverage, the slant against outside leverage), and **talent** (a receiver who simply beats his man). Mesh, the purest man-beater, gets the double "+" in the Cover 0 and Cover 1 columns; the figure in the two-way section below shows it.

2-Man is the exception that explains the rule. With two deep safeties over the top, the underneath defenders can trail their receivers with inside leverage and give up nothing deep, so the vertical concepts (four verticals, smash's corner route, yankee) all run into a defender underneath and a safety above. It is the most orange column of the matrix for that reason: almost every concept built to stretch a zone is worse against it. Its weaknesses are short and outside, away from the trailing defenders, and in the quarterback's legs: with every defender's back turned to him, a scramble often gains more than any throw.

Against pressure: get it out, or throw it where they left

The last column is the one that answers Zone Blitzes, Fire Zones, and Simulated Pressure. Against any blitz the first answer is time: the deep concepts (dagger, scissors, yankee) need three seconds or more, so dagger and scissors grade orange against both Cover 0 and fire zones and yankee against fire zones, unless the protection can block everyone. The second answer depends on what is behind the blitz.

- **Cover 0** has nobody deep and everybody in man. The answer is the quick man-beater (mesh, slants, a rub) or the hot throw to the receiver whose defender blitzed, thrown before the extra rusher arrives. A one-on-one go route with no safety behind it is a touchdown if the ball can get out, which is why the cell for four verticals is grey rather than orange.
- **A fire zone** has three deep and three underneath. It is built to take away the hot throw: the dropper lands in the window a hot slant or a quick in-cut wants. So the answers are the throws it can't cover with three underneath: the seams, which the seam-flat defenders have to carry alone (four verticals and flood grade "+"), the window *behind* the dropper (a lineman can't get much deeper than 5 or 6 yards in time), and screens, thrown behind rushers who have committed to the quarterback.

A short history: why the matrix keeps changing

The idea of choosing a pass play to beat a particular coverage is as old as coverages that could be studied. Sid Gillman, who coached the Los Angeles Rams in the late 1950s and the AFL's Chargers in the 1960s, is usually credited with two of its foundations: studying opponents on film, cut up and spliced by play, and designing pass patterns to stretch a defense across the whole field, vertically and horizontally, so that zone defenders faced more receivers than they could cover. Bill Walsh, who said that much of what he did derived from Gillman, built those ideas into the West Coast offense's progressions.¹ The rules then tilted the field. In 1978 the NFL allowed defenders to contact a receiver only within the first five yards past the line of scrimmage, which made it far harder for defenses to disrupt routes and far more valuable for offenses to read coverage and throw on time (1978 and the Passing Revolution tells that story).²

The defense's side of the history is the story of Part 6 told backwards. Each famous beater produced a counter. Four verticals against spot-drop Cover 3, a staple of the run-and-shoot and BYU passing games by the 1980s, helped produce pattern-matching

¹"Sid Gillman," Pro Football Hall of Fame (Class of 1983; Chargers head coach and general manager 1960–1969): <https://www.profootballhof.com/players/sid-gillman/>; "Sid Gillman," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sid_Gillman (Rams head coach 1955–1959, Chargers 1960–1969 and 1971; his early film study; using "the length and width of the field"; Walsh's acknowledgement that "much of what he did derived from Gillman"). Walsh never coached on Gillman's staff; the influence came through Gillman's disciples, Al Davis among them.

²Pro Football Hall of Fame, "1978" (football history chronology): <https://www.profootballhof.com/football-history/football-history/1960-1979/1978> ("Rules changes permitted a defender to maintain contact with a receiver within five yards of the line of scrimmage, but restricted contact beyond that point.")

Cover 3, usually traced to Nick Saban and Bill Belichick in Cleveland in the early 1990s (Cover 3).³ Smash and the quick game against Cover 2 helped produce Palms and the quarters family. And the spread offenses of the 2000s and 2010s, which could create a one-on-one or a numbers advantage against any single coverage, helped push NFL defenses toward the disguised two-high shells that spread after 2018 (Fangio’s Two-High Revolution and Macdonald’s Answer). The matrix in this chapter is a snapshot of the mid-2020s. Its rows and columns will look different in ten years, because both sides are always working on the cells that hurt them.

Why “beaters” are bets

If offenses know which concept beats which coverage, why doesn’t every pass work? Because a beater only beats the coverage the defense *actually plays, as it actually plays it*, and four things stand between the call sheet and that coverage.

1. The defense chose its coverage too, and it hid it. The play-caller picks a concept before the snap, often before the huddle breaks, from a guess about the coverage. The defensive coordinator picks the coverage at the same time, from a guess about the concept, and then disguises it. Neither sees the other’s card. A smash call that meets Cover 2 looks brilliant on the replay; the same call against 2-Man looks like a mistake, and the play-caller is the same man with the same information. The rotation at the start of this chapter is the everyday version: the offense called a Cover 2 beater and got Cover 3.

2. Coverage labels hide different rules. “Cover 3” names a family, not a set of instructions. Against spot-drop Cover 3, four verticals is a math problem the defense loses; against Cover 3 match, whose seam-flat defenders carry the slot receivers, it meets four defenders deep and the math is gone. The label in the matrix is the same; the behaviour after the snap is not. Quarters, Cover 6 and Palms look identical before the snap and play completely differently against the same concept. Every match coverage is a set of if-then rules (Quarters and the Two-High Match Family), and the “beater” depends on which rules this staff teaches.

3. Execution and talent. A beater produces a window; somebody still has to hit it. The window in the smash plate is about five yards wide and opens for perhaps half a second. A protection that breaks at 2.2 seconds, a corner route run a yard too flat, a ball thrown a beat late, a defender who is simply faster than the diagram assumed: each closes it. And the reverse happens constantly. Great receivers beat good coverage with bad matchups, and great quarterbacks complete throws into coverages the play was not designed for. That is why the best players change the matrix, which describes average players.

4. Situation and the second read. The defense doesn’t play coverages at random; it plays them by down, distance, field position, personnel and score (Tendencies, PROE, and Charting). On third-and-long, a defense can sit back in deep coverage and concede the short throw, so a concept can “beat” the coverage and still lose the down if its open receiver is two yards short of the sticks. Beating the coverage and moving the chains are different things.

What the data say: the edges are real, and small

You can’t count concepts in public data: play-by-play records where the ball went, not what was drawn. But you can count something close to the matrix’s ingredients. Next Gen Stats charting in nflverse records, for many dropbacks, the coverage the defense played after the snap and the route run by the receiver who was targeted. Here is the success rate (the share of plays with positive expected points added) for each common route against each coverage, over five regular seasons.

³Cameron Soran, “The Complete Guide to Nick Saban Coverages at Alabama,” Throw Deep Publishing (Feb. 24, 2021): <https://throwdeeppublishing.com/blogs/news/nick-saban-s-alabama-pass-coverages> (a pattern-matching form of Cover 3 that “prior to his association with Belichick with the Browns in the early 1990s simply did not exist”). Saban was Cleveland’s defensive coordinator under Belichick from 1991 to 1994. Which offenses forced the change is the usual coaching account, not a documented record.

		Cover 0	Cover 1	2-Man	Cover 2	Cover 3	Quarters (Cover 4)	Cover 6
Route run by the targeted receiver	Hitch / curl	48%	52%	38%	63%	60%	58%	56%
	Out	50%	53%	53%	54%	58%	57%	52%
	Slant	48%	59%	53%	61%	61%	59%	59%
	Crosser	50%	53%	48%	49%	54%	51%	52%
	In / dig	49%	51%	50%	61%	58%	53%	59%
	Corner	49%	40%	n=55	49%	50%	45%	51%
	Post	45%	50%	46%	57%	55%	43%	51%
	Go / fade	28%	34%	37%	43%	37%	31%	38%

Figure 7: Success rate of targeted passes by the route the targeted receiver ran and the coverage the defense played after the snap, NFL regular seasons 2018–2022 (sacks excluded; a play is a success if it added expected points). Blue is above the average for these throws, orange below. Cells with fewer than 100 targets are left blank. The edges the matrix predicts are there, but they are a few percentage points, not a switch: hitches and curls succeed most against the zones whose corners give ground (Cover 2, Cover 3) and least against 2-Man; corner routes do worst against man (Cover 1); go routes, boom-or-bust by nature, succeed least often everywhere but most against Cover 2, the hole shot. No cell is near certainty. Source: nflverse play-by-play and participation data (Next Gen Stats coverage and route labels), course calculation.

Read it the way an analyst would. Across 63,058 targeted throws, the average success rate is 52%. The best cell is 63% and the worst 28%, and most cells sit within ten points of the average. Some of the matrix’s logic shows clearly: a hitch or curl thrown against Cover 2 succeeds 63% of the time and against 2-Man only 38%, because a hitch in front of a corner who is giving ground is a different throw from a hitch against a defender sitting on it with a safety behind him. Go routes do best against Cover 2 (43%) and worst against quarters (31%), which has a deep defender for every vertical route (only Cover 0, at 28%, is lower). Corner routes are a poor bet against Cover 1 (40%).⁴

Two cautions keep the chart honest. First, it shows only the route *thrown to*, and the quarterback chooses that route after seeing the coverage, so every cell is already the result of someone’s read. A corner route thrown against Cover 3 is mostly the flattened corner that coverage allows, not the smash corner that would have run into the deep third. Second, success rate punishes deep routes, which fail more often and win bigger. Neither caution changes the headline: **even the best matchups fail more than a third of the time**. A coverage beater moves the odds by a few points per throw. Over a season of about 600 dropbacks, a few points per throw is a great deal, which is why coordinators spend their week on it (The Game-Planning Week).

Calling against a menu, not a coverage

So a play-caller doesn’t pick the beater for *the* coverage; he picks the concept with the best expected result against the coverages this defense is likely to play in this situation. That is a weighted average, and you can do it with the matrix. Suppose that on second-and-7, film study says a defense plays Cover 3 35% of the time, Cover 1 25%, quarters 25% and Cover 2 15%. Score each grade as a number from –2 to +2, weight it by how often the coverage comes, and add:

⁴Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play (`load_pbp`) joined to participation data (`load_participation`), NFL regular seasons 2018–2022, pass attempts with a targeted receiver, sacks excluded, `route` and `defense_coverage_type` both recorded. Both labels come from Next Gen Stats for these seasons; 2023–2025 participation comes from FTN with different route and coverage labels, so those seasons are not pooled here. “Success” is nflverse’s `success` flag (expected points added greater than zero). The route is the targeted receiver’s only, as charted.

Table 2: A play-caller's arithmetic: matrix grades weighted by a hypothetical defense's second-and-7 coverage mix.

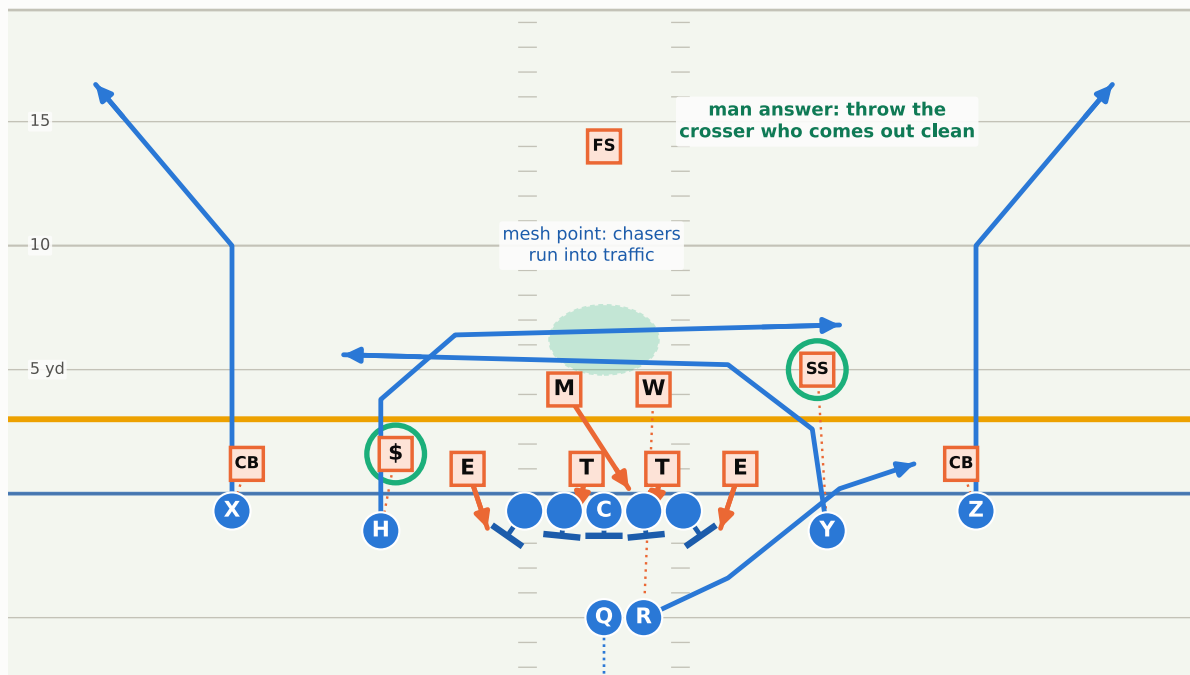
Concept	Cover 3 (35%)	Cover 1 (25%)	Quarters (25%)	Cover 2 (15%)	Expected grade	Worst case
Smash	+1	-1	0	+2	+0.40	-1
Flood	+2	-1	+1	+1	+0.85	-1
Mesh	0	+2	0	0	+0.50	0
Dagger	0	0	+2	+1	+0.65	0
Four verticals	+2	0	-1	+1	+0.60	-1

Flood wins on average, because the most common coverage is the one it beats. But notice the last column. Flood is bad against man, and one snap in four is man. Mesh and dagger never go below zero. If the down is third-and-7 and a bad play ends the drive, a careful coordinator may prefer the call with no bad outcome to the one with the best average. That is the logic of the next section.

Two-way concepts: an answer for man and an answer for zone

A **two-way concept** has an answer built in for both man and zone coverage, so it isn't a bad call whatever the defense plays. There are two ways to build one. The routes themselves can work against both (crossing routes rub against man and settle into holes against zone), or a receiver can change his route after the snap according to the coverage, the option route of Passing Game Fundamentals, whose runner breaks away from his defender against man and sits down in the window against zone. Mesh is the classic of the first kind.

Against Cover 1 (man): the rub



Against Cover 3 (zone): sit in the holes

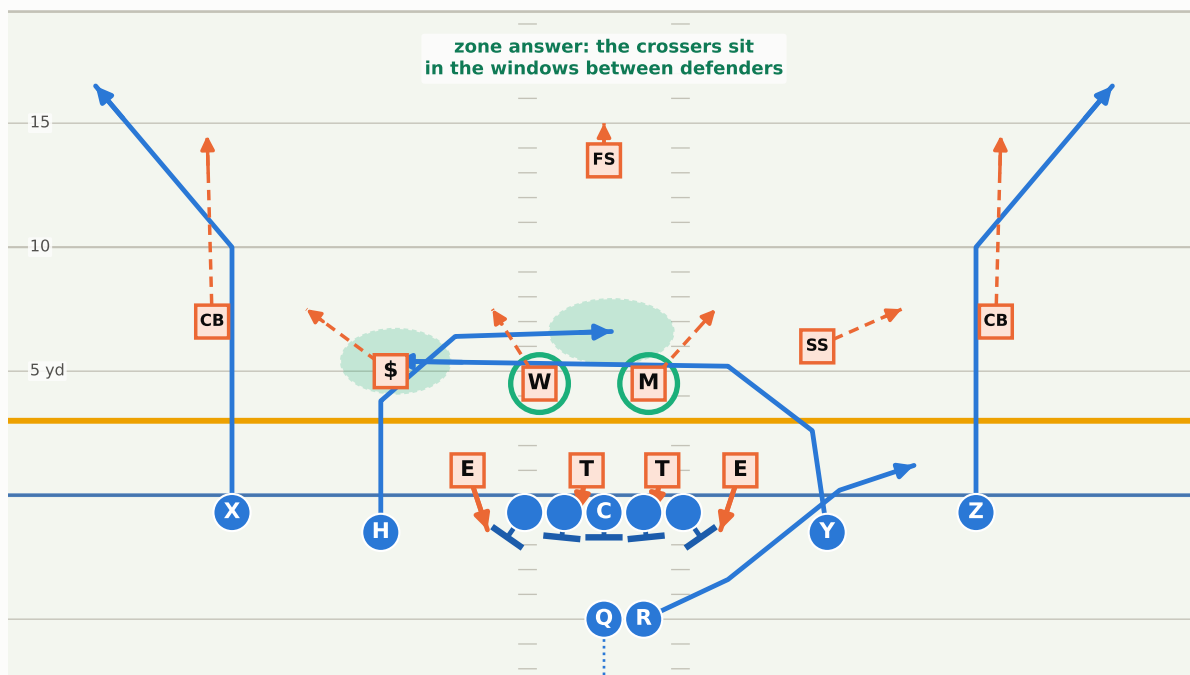


Figure 8: Mesh as a two-way concept, third-and-3. Top, against Cover 1 (a recap of the animation in Dropback Concepts): H and Y cross over the ball at 5 to 6 yards, H a step higher, so the defenders chasing them in man, the nickel (\$) and the strong safety (SS), both ringed, have to get around one receiver to stay with the other (dotted lines are the man assignments). The quarterback throws to whichever crosser comes out of the traffic first. Bottom, the same play against Cover 3: there is nobody chasing, so each crosser settles in the first window past a hook defender (ringed) and turns to face the quarterback (green). The corner routes give a high-low on the outside in both pictures, and the back runs to the flat.

Notice what the two-way concept costs. Against zone, mesh's crossers are *fine*, settling for five or six yards in front of defenders who rally to them; they are not a zone beater the way flood is. In the matrix, mesh is grey across the zone columns: never bad,

rarely great. That is the trade. A two-way concept gives up some of the ceiling of a pure beater to raise the floor. On third-and-3, where five or six yards is a first down and a bad call ends the drive, that is a bargain. On first-and-10, where a coordinator can afford a swing for a big gain, he may prefer the pure beater and accept that it will sometimes meet the wrong coverage.

There are three common ways offenses build two-way plays:

- **Routes that work against both.** Mesh, drive and the shallow cross rub against man and find holes against zone. So does a slant run inside a defender with outside leverage.
- **Choices inside one route.** The option route, the “sit or go” seam that stays straight against one deep safety and bends into the open middle against two (a route conversion), and the hitch that turns into a fade against press: each receiver reads the coverage after the snap, and the quarterback reads the same thing.
- **A man side and a zone side.** Put a zone beater on one half of the field (curl-flat, smash) and a man-beater on the other (a rub, a slant-flat), and let the quarterback choose his half from the man/zone read: the man/zone indicator on a motion before the snap, or the corners’ first steps after it. This is called a *half-field* or *combination* call, and many third-down playbooks are built from them.

All three ask more of the quarterback and the receivers than a single beater does, because now both of them must read the coverage the same way, at speed. When they disagree, the result is the interception where the receiver turned out and the ball went in. That is why two-way concepts are a veteran offense’s tool and why young quarterbacks are often given simpler, single-answer calls.

The defense answers back

If the offense’s job is to call the concept that beats the defense’s coverage, the defense’s job is to play a coverage that beats the offense’s concept, or at least doesn’t lose to it. Defenses fight the matrix in three ways.

Change the coverage’s rules against a known concept. This is the match idea from Part 6 seen as a counter. The clearest example is four verticals against Cover 3. Spot-drop Cover 3 loses to it by arithmetic; Cover 3 match changes one rule, the seam-flat defender’s, and the arithmetic is gone.

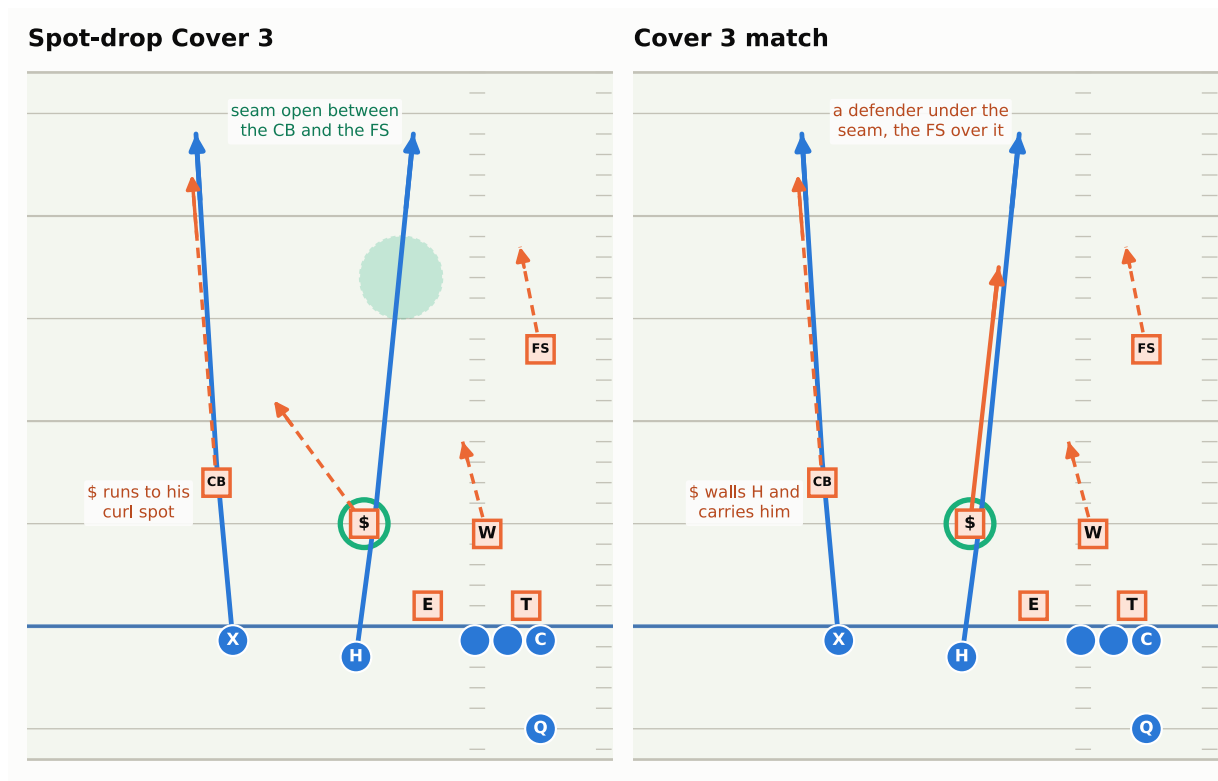


Figure 9: The defense’s counter to four verticals, left half of the field (H’s and X’s routes; the right side is the mirror image). Left, spot-drop Cover 3: the nickel (\$, ringed) runs to his curl landmark, wide and about 11 yards deep, so H’s seam runs past him on the inside and arrives in the gap between the deep-third corner and the free safety (green). Right, Cover 3 match: the same nickel reads #2 (H) and, because H goes vertical, walls him and carries him up the seam. Now the seam has a defender underneath it and the free safety over it, and the ball has nowhere to go. One rule changed; the concept’s best throw disappeared. (Cover 3 draws both as moving plays.)

The diagram illustrates a football play on a field with yard lines every 5 yards. A wide receiver (WR) is shown in a blue circle, starting at the line of scrimmage (LOS) and running a route that includes a backpedal, a cut to the right, and a vertical run. A cornerback (CB) is shown in a blue circle, starting at the LOS and running a short, vertical route. The WR's route is marked with a blue line and arrows, while the CB's route is marked with a red line and arrows. The WR's route is labeled with 'WR' and the CB's route is labeled with 'CB'. The diagram also shows the positions of other players: the quarterback (QB) in a blue circle, the running back (RB) in a blue circle, the tight end (TE) in a blue circle, and the offensive line (OL) in blue circles. The defensive line (DL) is shown in blue circles. The diagram is annotated with text boxes: 'both smash throws covered: work back to the checkdown' (green), '#2 went vertical: the SS carries the corner route' (red), and '#1 stopped short: the CB sits on the hitch' (red). The diagram is titled 'WR Route' in the top left corner.

Take the beater's target away directly. Brackets, robbers and lurkers put an extra defender where a known concept wants to throw (Man Coverage). A defense that expects mesh on third-and-short can sit a linebacker at the mesh point, at five yards over the ball, so the crossers run into him instead of past each other. A defense that expects dagger can rob the dig with a safety who ignores the seam.

And the offense answers the answers. Every counter has a hole of its own, and the defense's counter becomes the next concept's target:

Table 3: Counters and counter-counters. Each answer creates the next question, which is why the matrix is never finished.

The defense's counter	What it takes away	What it opens	The offense's counter-counter
Cover 3 match	four verticals	the flat and space behind carries	post-wheel; switch releases; the back to the flat
Palms	smash; quick outs by #2	the corner jumping #2	out-and-up or wheel by #2; double move by #1
Tampa 2	the seams between the safeties	the Mike's depth; the curl windows	read the Mike: throw the seam he didn't take; levels under him
Robber or lurk	in-cuts and crossers	the side he leaves	look him off; throw behind him
2-Man	vertical stretches	out-breaking routes, the back, scrambles	quick outs; RB routes; designed quarterback runs
Fire zone	the hot throw	the seams; the window behind the dropper	seams; screens; throw over the dropper

Which side is ahead at any moment depends on who has the newer answer and the better players. That back-and-forth over many plays, how a coordinator sets up one call with another, is the subject of Constraint Theory: How Plays Talk to Each Other.

The alert: calling the shot before the snap

One more pre-snap tool turns the coverage read into a big play. An **alert** (many staffs say shot alert) is a pre-planned exception to the called play: *if* the quarterback sees a particular look before the snap, he throws to the alert receiver first, usually on a deep route; if he doesn't see it, he runs the play as called. The play-caller builds it in; the quarterback decides at the line.

The classic trigger is a **single deep safety with the offense's best receiver isolated** on the other side of the field, one-on-one against a corner with no help leaning his way. That is the situation in which a deep throw has the best odds and the highest payoff: the receiver only has to beat one man, and if he does, nobody is behind the corner. Other alerts are keyed to Cover 0 (any one-on-one deep with no safety at all), to a corner pressing with the wrong leverage, or to a safety cheating down into the box against play-action. A shot play from Play-Action, Bootlegs, and Screens is called *to* take a deep shot; an alert is a shot that the defense has to *give*.

Why not just call the deep shot? Because the deep shot is a bad play against most coverages and a great one against a few, and the alert lets the offense take it only when the coverage shows that it is one of the few. The called play underneath is the insurance. **What it costs** is that the quarterback makes the decision before the snap, which is exactly the moment the defense is lying to him. Alerts are therefore built around looks that are hard to fake: a single safety who can't get back to the alert side in time, whatever he does at the snap, or a corner pressed with no help. If the safety rotates over at the snap, a good quarterback abandons the alert and goes back to the play.

Putting it together: identify, then predict

Everything above reduces to a routine you can run on any passing play, live or on the replay. It is the same four steps as the quarterback's, minus the throwing.

1. **Before the snap:** call the shell and the most likely two coverages. Note the formation's strength and any isolated receiver (an alert candidate).
2. **At the snap:** watch the two safeties. One in the middle, two splitting the field, or none?
3. **One second after:** watch the corners (squat, bail, trail or read) to name the coverage within its family. Then find the defender the concept puts in conflict. You may not know the concept yet, but you can see where the receivers are going: two to one sideline at two depths means a high-low on that side's corner or curl-flat defender; a slot running up the seam means somebody's rule about #2 is being tested.
4. **Predict the open man** before the ball is thrown. Say it out loud. Then watch where the ball goes.

The four animated plays in this chapter are drills for exactly this. Run them again (on the website they are videos; in print, cover panels 3 and 4 with your hand) and, at panel 2, name the coverage and the open receiver before you look.

Film room

The famous concept-against-coverage plays have homes of their own in this book: the Chiefs' "Jet Chip Wasp" on third-and-15 in Super Bowl LIV is drawn in Case Study: Andy Reid's Chiefs, and the Super Bowl XLIX interception at the goal line, a rub concept met by a defense ready for it, in Case Study: Belichick's Patriots and the Game Plan. Here are three more recent pictures of this chapter's ideas.

i Film room: Chiefs, Super Bowls LVII and LVIII — the man-beater, and its counter

In Super Bowl LVII (February 12, 2023, the 2022 season) the Eagles played a lot of man coverage against Kansas City, and two of the Chiefs' fourth-quarter touchdowns, the go-ahead score and the one that followed it, came from the same idea. On both, a receiver went in motion across the formation and then, as the ball was snapped, turned and ran back the way he had come. Kadarius Toney scored on the first; Skyy Moore on the second, after his defender started across the formation with him. "As soon as I went in motion and I saw him come in motion with me, I knew I had him," Moore said afterwards. Andy Reid's name for Toney's play was "Corn Dog."⁵

That is a man-beater in its purest form: it attacks the one thing man coverage must do, follow a receiver, and uses the defender's own movement against him. A year later, in overtime of Super Bowl LVIII (February 11, 2024), the Chiefs ran the same motion on first-and-goal from the 3-yard line. This time the call, "Tom and Jerry," was built on the assumption that the 49ers would be ready for it. "We built corn dog in saying, for sure they'll cover corn dog," Reid said. The first answer on the play was a shovel pass to running back Jerick McKinnon underneath; when the 49ers converged on the shovel and played man on the outside, Patrick Mahomes threw to Mecole Hardman, breaking back to the flat, for the championship-winning touchdown.⁶

What to notice: the play-caller designed for the defense's *counter* to the beater, not for the beater itself. On any goal-line snap, watch the first defender to react to a motion. If he follows, it's man, and the motion man's turn back is the throw.

i Film room: Seahawks 2025 — two-high, and what offenses could do about it

Mike Macdonald's 2025 Seahawks won Super Bowl LX playing more two-high coverage than any other playoff team: from Week 14 through the Super Bowl, Next Gen Stats counted split-safety coverage on 54.8% of their opponents' pass plays, up from 46% in the nine games safety Julian Love missed. Seattle won all eight games after Love's return, allowing 15.1 points a game. Across the league, offenses converted 29.0% of dropbacks into first downs against split-safety coverage in 2025, tied for the lowest rate since at least 2018.⁷

What to notice: this is the matrix's quarters and Cover 6 columns in real life. Against two-high, the concepts that work are the ones that make a read safety pay for his rule (dagger, scissors, the quick out to #2) and, above all, the run, because two safeties 12 yards deep leave a light box. The league noticed: in 2025, offenses used fewer than three wide receivers on 41.7% of plays, the first season at or above 38% since NGS began counting in 2016.⁸ Bigger personnel is partly a run-game answer to two-high coverage. When you watch a two-high defense, count the run calls before you count the beaters.

⁵Jonathan Jones, "Super Bowl 2023: Patrick Mahomes, Chiefs outmanned Eagles defense when it mattered the most," CBS Sports (Feb. 13, 2023): <https://www.cbssports.com/nfl/news/super-bowl-2023-patrick-mahomes-chiefs-outmanned-eagles-defense-when-it-mattered-the-most> (the Eagles' man coverage; Toney's touchdown came with Kansas City trailing 27–21 in the fourth quarter, Moore's less than three minutes later off similar motion; Moore's quote). The play name: Bryan DeArdo, "'Corn dog' joins Chiefs Super Bowl lore: Andy Reid says Kadarius Toney TD came on a play with an unusual name," CBS Sports (Feb. 13, 2023): <https://www.cbssports.com/nfl/news/corn-dog-joins-chiefs-super-bowl-lore-andy-reid-says-kadarius-toney-td-came-on-a-play-with-an-unusual-name>.

⁶Jason Owens, "Andy Reid surprised that 49ers bit on game-winning Super Bowl motion: 'For sure they'll cover corn dog,'" Yahoo Sports (Feb. 13, 2024): <https://sports.yahoo.com/andy-reid-surprised-49ers-bit-on-game-winning-super-bowl-motion-for-sure-theyll-cover-corn-dog-232659275.html> (Reid's quotes; the 49ers "converged on the shovel" and "manned it up on the outside"). Score and overtime: Chiefs 25, 49ers 22 (OT), per the course fact sheet. First-and-goal from the 49ers' 3, the 3-yard touchdown, and the shovel to McKinnon as the play's designed first option: "Tom and Jerry (American football)," Wikipedia: [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tom_and_Jerry_\(American_football\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tom_and_Jerry_(American_football)).

⁷NFL Next Gen Stats Analytics Team, "The coverage that turned the Seahawks into Super Bowl winners and is taking the NFL by storm," NFL.com (2026, after Super Bowl LX; the page carries no date): <https://www.nfl.com/news/the-coverage-that-turned-the-seahawks-into-super-bowl-winners-and-is-taking-the-nfl-by-storm> (54.8% from Week 14, Love's first game back, through Super Bowl LX, "the highest rate of any playoff team in that span"; 46% in the nine games he missed; 8–0 and 15.1 points allowed after his return; 29.0% first-down rate, "tied for the lowest mark since at least 2018"). Split-safety is NGS's post-snap two-high measure; do not mix it with the TruMedia/538 early-down series.

⁸NFL Next Gen Stats Analytics Team, "NFL trend watch: heavy personnel could shape Super Bowl LX showdown between Patriots and Seahawks," NFL.com (2026): <https://www.nfl.com/news/nfl-trend-watch-heavy-personnel-could-shape-super-bowl-lx-showdown-between-patriots-and-seahawks> ("Offenses used sub packages with fewer than three wide receivers on 41.7% of plays; the average had been below 38% in every one of the prior nine seasons since Next Gen Stats was established in 2016").

i Film room: Matthew Stafford, 2025 — the quarterback who beat two-high

Matthew Stafford won the 2025 MVP award with a league-leading 46 touchdown passes.⁹ In the nflverse charting, he was also among the best quarterbacks in the league against two-high coverage: on 249 dropbacks against Cover 2, 2-Man, quarters or Cover 6 he averaged +0.26 expected points added per dropback, third best of the 25 quarterbacks with at least 150 such dropbacks, against a league average of +0.02.¹⁰

What to notice: what a quarterback brings to the matrix. Two-high coverage is built to take away the deep throw and the easy read; it is beaten by a quarterback who identifies the coverage at the snap, moves a safety with his eyes and throws on time into a window between the levels: the dig behind a read safety, the seam the Mike didn't carry. On a Rams passing down from 2025, watch Stafford's helmet in the first second after the snap. It often goes where the ball isn't going.

Watch for it on Sunday

💡 Watch for it

Predict the open man. For one quarter, on every dropback pass, make the coverage call and then a prediction, before the ball is thrown.

- **Before the snap:** shell (one-high or two-high), corners (press or off), and the two coverages you think are most likely. Is a receiver isolated against a single safety? That's an alert candidate.
- **One second after the snap:** how many safeties in the middle? Then the corners: squat (Cover 2), bail (Cover 3), read (quarters), trail (man). Say the coverage out loud.
- **Name the conflict defender** on the side the routes are going: the corner (two receivers at two depths outside), the curl-flat defender (three at three levels), the read safety (a slot going up the seam), the matchup (crossers against man).
- **Predict the open receiver** from what that defender does, *before* the throw. Then watch.
- **Watch the quarterback's helmet.** Did he look one way and throw the other? Who moved?

For your log: coverage called, receiver predicted, receiver thrown to. Score yourself on the predictions. Over a quarter you'll find that you get Cover 3 and Cover 2 right far more often than quarters and match coverages, which is exactly the point of those coverages.

⁹"List of NFL Honors award winners from 2025 NFL season," NFL.com: <https://amp.nfl.com/news/list-of-nfl-honors-award-winners-from-2025-nfl-season>.

¹⁰Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play joined to participation data, 2025 regular season, quarterback dropbacks (sacks and scrambles included) with a charted `defense_coverage_type`, BLOWN and COMBO excluded; two-high = COVER_2, 2_MAN, COVER_4, COVER_6. The 2025 coverage labels come from FTN charting. A ranking by one season's EPA on a subset of plays is noisy; read it as "among the best," not as an exact order.

Predict the play

💡 Predict the play 1: the isolated receiver

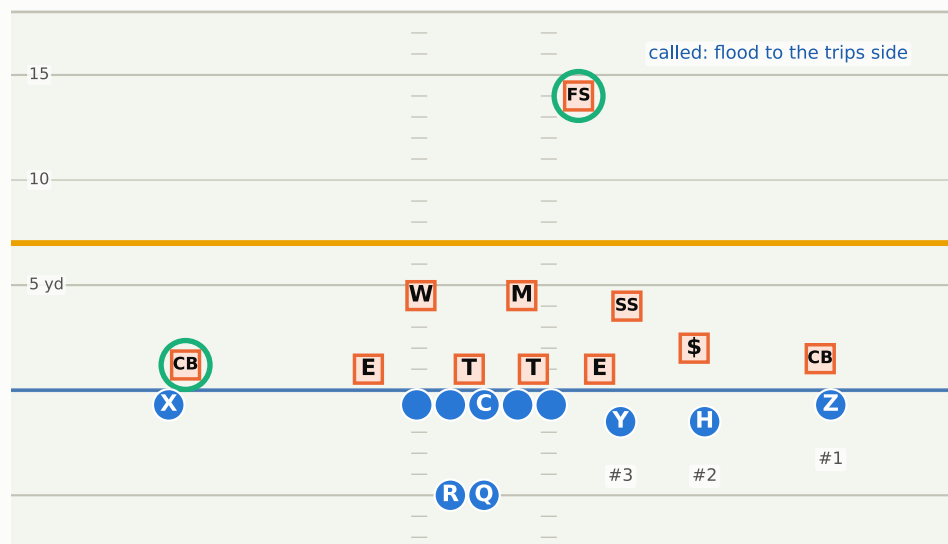


Figure 11: Second-and-7 near midfield. The offense is in detached trips to the right (#1, #2 and #3 labelled) with X alone on the left. The defense shows one deep safety, who is standing 4 or 5 yards toward the trips side, and man-looking corners: the left corner presses X with an inside shade. The called play is a flood to the trips side.

Before the snap: does the quarterback stay with the called play, or is there a better throw?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 2: 1.1 seconds into four verticals

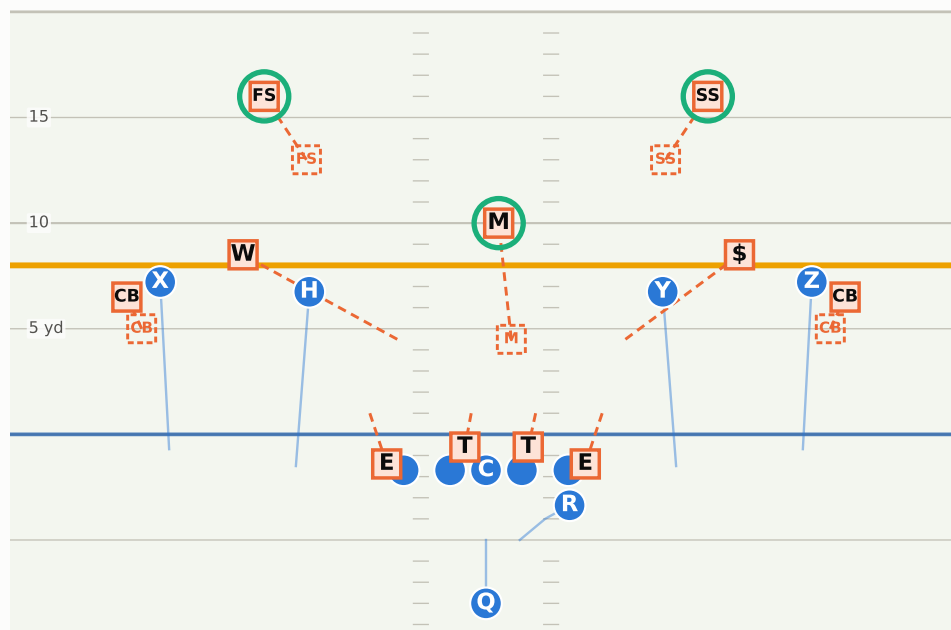


Figure 12: Second-and-8. The offense runs four verticals. The picture is 1.1 seconds after the snap; dashed outlines show where the ringed defenders started. Both corners squatted at about 6 yards. The two safeties have widened to about 10 or 11 yards outside the middle and 16 deep. The Mike (M, ringed) has turned and is running straight down the middle of the field.

What is the coverage, which defender should the quarterback read, and where will the ball go?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 3: you call it

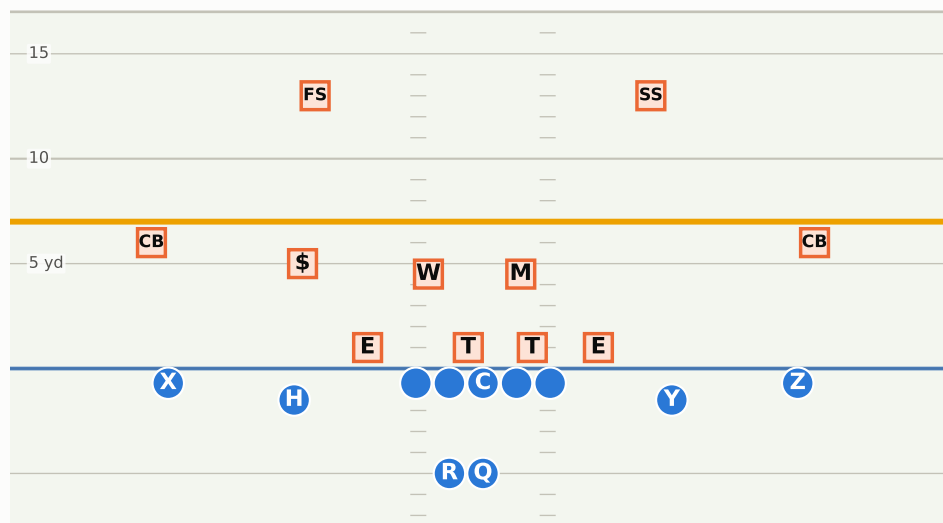


Figure 13: Third-and-7 near midfield, your offense in its 2x2 set. The defense shows two-high with both corners 6 yards off. Film study says that on third-and-medium against this formation it played Cover 2 30% of the time, quarters 35%, 2-Man 20%, and rotated to Cover 3 the other 15%.

You have four concepts on the call sheet: smash, flood, dagger and mesh. Using the matrix grades, which has the best expected result? Which has the safest floor? Which would you call, and why?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- **The quarterback reads coverage in four steps:** the shell before the snap (a hypothesis), the rotation at it (the middle open or closed one second later), the key defender after it (the one the concept puts in conflict), and the throw that defender leaves. The look-off is the same read run in reverse: move the key defender with your eyes, then throw where he was.
- **Every cell of the concept-by-coverage matrix follows from two questions:** where are this coverage's thin spots, and does it give help to the defender this concept attacks? Smash beats Cover 2 at the sideline; flood and four verticals beat Cover 3's arithmetic; dagger and scissors make quarters' read safeties pay for their rule; mesh beats man with traffic; quick throws, seams and screens beat pressure.
- **Beaters are bets.** Disguise hides the coverage, match rules change what a label means, execution and talent widen or close windows, and the defense chooses by situation too. In charting data the edges are real but small: even the best route-against-coverage matchups fail more than a third of the time.
- **Two-way concepts trade ceiling for floor.** Built-in answers for man and for zone mean the call is never bad, at the cost of rarely being great; they rule third down.
- **The matrix is never finished.** Every defensive counter (Cover 3 match, Palms, Tampa 2, robbers) opens something new, and the offense's next concept attacks it. The shot alert lets the offense take a deep shot only when the coverage gives it.
- **Watching:** call the coverage one second after the snap, find the conflict defender, and predict the open man before the throw.

Connections

Builds on: Dropback Concepts (the concepts and the defender each one attacks), Quarterback Play (the progression and the key defender), Man Coverage, Cover 3, Cover 2 and Tampa 2 and Quarters and the Two-High Match Family (each coverage's thin spots), Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage (why the pre-snap read is only a hypothesis) and Zone Blitzes, Fire Zones, and Simulated Pressure (the pressure column).

Sets up: Constraint Theory: How Plays Talk to Each Other, which turns the counter-and-counter-counter table into a theory of play-calling; The Game-Planning Week, where coordinators build the call sheet from the opponent's coverage tendencies, the

matrix arithmetic done for real; and Third Down: The Money Down, where two-way concepts and pressure answers decide drives. The Coverage and Pressure Atlas keeps a one-page copy of the matrix.

Case studies: Case Study: Belichick's Patriots and the Game Plan (taking away what an offense does best, week by week, and the Super Bowl XLIX interception) and Case Study: Andy Reid's Chiefs (Jet Chip Wasp, and an offense built on beating whatever coverage it gets).

Go deeper

- Chris B. Brown, *The Essential Smart Football* (2012) and *The Art of Smart Football* (2015): short, clear essays on concepts, coverages and the quarterback's read, including smash, four verticals and the coverage-beater idea.
- Cody Alexander, *Match Quarters* and his MatchQuarters newsletter: how modern defenses build rules that take away specific concepts, from the defensive coach's side.
- Ted Nguyen's film breakdowns at *The Athletic* and Emory Willhite's newsletter: concept-against-coverage cut-ups from NFL games, play by play.
- NFL Next Gen Stats' coverage articles on NFL.com: league-wide numbers on two-high, man and blitz rates, season by season.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

This is the textbook alert: throw to X first. One deep safety, already leaning toward the trips, means X is one-on-one with no help on his side. The corner pressing him is shaded inside, so he is taking away the slant and conceding the outside: the alert throw is a fade or a back-shoulder throw up the left sideline. If X wins at the line, the throw has a high chance of a big gain, and the safety, 4 or 5 yards the wrong way and 14 deep, can't get there in time.

The insurance: if the safety rotates back toward X at the snap, or the corner bails off the press, the alert is off and the quarterback works the flood to the trips side, where three receivers now face a defense that has shifted its help that way. And the defense knows all of this: a single safety cheating to trips is sometimes bait for exactly this throw, with a rotation back at the snap. That is why an alert is decided before the snap but confirmed in the first half-second after it.

Answer 2.

Tampa 2. Two safeties splitting the field (middle open), corners squatting in the flats (Cover 2 corners), and the Mike running down the middle: that is the Tampa 2 Mike, whose job is to carry the most dangerous seam and close the gap between the safeties that four verticals is built to hit.

Read the Mike, then a safety. The Mike can only carry one seam. Whichever he takes, the other seam is a one-on-one high-low on that side's safety: the seam inside him and the go route outside him. If the safety stays inside on the seam, the go route is open along the sideline behind the squatting corner (the hole shot); if he widens toward the go route, as these two already have, the seam splits the gap between him and the Mike. With both safeties wide here, the likely throw is the seam away from the Mike. If the quarterback can't decide in time, the back underneath, past the two hook defenders who have dropped deep under the verticals, is the checkdown. This is why four verticals is only a "+" against Cover 2 in the matrix, not a "++": the Tampa Mike takes away half of the concept.

Answer 3.

Weight each grade by the coverage mix (Cover 2 30%, quarters 35%, 2-Man 20%, Cover 3 15%):

- **Smash:** +2, 0, -2, +1 $\rightarrow 0.60 + 0 - 0.40 + 0.15 = +0.35$, worst case -2 (2-Man).
- **Flood:** +1, +1, -1, +2 $\rightarrow 0.30 + 0.35 - 0.20 + 0.30 = +0.75$, worst case -1.
- **Dagger:** +1, +2, -1, 0 $\rightarrow 0.30 + 0.70 - 0.20 + 0 = +0.80$, worst case -1.
- **Mesh:** 0, 0, +1, 0 $\rightarrow +0.20$, worst case 0.

Dagger has the best average, because the most likely coverage, quarters, is the one it was built to beat, and it is decent against Cover 2 too. Flood is a close second. Mesh never loses but rarely wins big. Smash, the famous Cover 2 beater, is the worst choice here: this defense plays enough 2-Man to punish it.

What a coordinator would add. Third-and-7 is a long-ish third down: dagger's dig, at 15 or 16 yards, is past the sticks, which helps. But dagger needs about three seconds, so the call depends on the protection and on whether this defense blitzes on third

down; against a pressure-heavy defense the slightly quicker flood, or a two-way call, might be safer. And the 20% of 2-Man is the danger in every choice except mesh: if the 2-Man share were higher, mesh's safe floor would start to look like the smart call. The matrix doesn't make the decision; it organises it.